

Spear Phishing Email Investigation

ExecuTalk Collaboration Software Scenario

CASE TYPE Spear phishing / credential phishing	TARGET Executive at Imaginary Bank	DISPOSITION QUARANTINE
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Executive Summary

This simulated investigation examines a spear-phishing email that impersonates a trusted business context and encourages an executive to install collaboration software called ExecuTalk. The message contains several independent warning signs, including a mismatched sender domain, repeated spelling and grammar errors, pressure to act within 48 hours, an unexpected software installation request, and a suspicious login page.

The evidence supports treating the message as malicious and quarantining it rather than allowing delivery or user interaction.

Portfolio note: This report is formatted as a cybersecurity project artifact suitable for a GitHub repository or LinkedIn document upload.

Step 1 - Analyze the Suspicious Email

From	imaginarybank@gmail.org
Sent	Saturday, December 21, 2019 15:05:05
To	cfo@imaginarybank.com
Subject	RE: You are been added to an ecsecutiv's groups

Message Body

Congratulations! You have been added to a collaboration group 'Execs.'
Downlode ExecuTalk to your computer.
Mac | Windows | Android
You're team needs you! This invitation will expire in 48 hours so act quickly.

Sincerely, ExecuTalk
All rights reserved.

Step 2 - Sender Analysis

The most important header clue is the sender domain. The message uses gmail.org, while the recipient is using an Imaginary Bank corporate address ending in imaginarybank.com. A request to install software or enter credentials from a personal/free-mail domain is a strong warning sign.

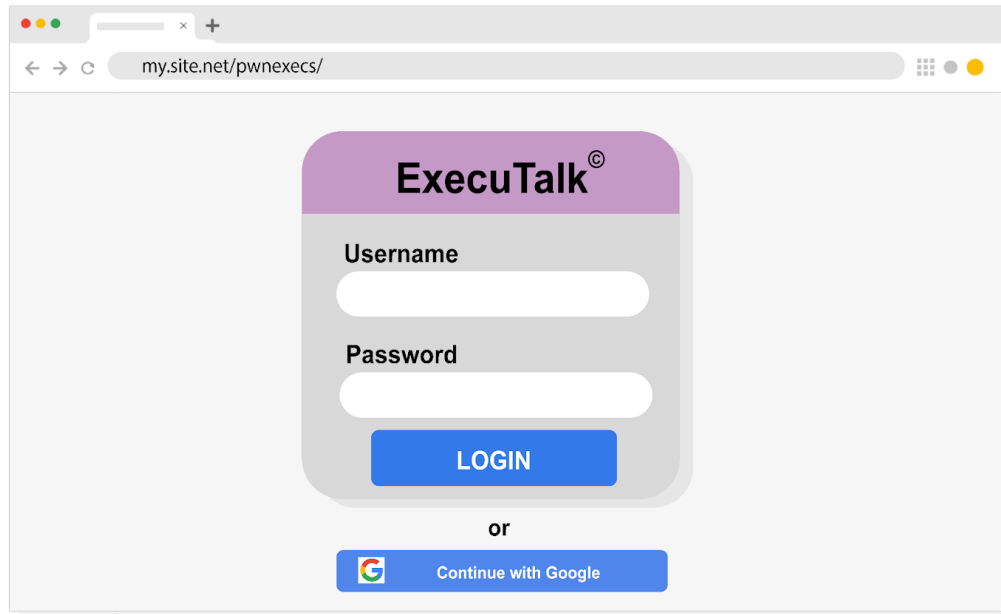
Additional header clue: the subject begins with RE:, which can make an unsolicited message appear to be part of an existing conversation.

Step 3 - Three Deception Techniques

#	Technique	How it is used
1	Impersonation	The message presents itself as a business invitation relevant to an executive and references an "Execs" group.
2	Legitimate-looking branding	The email uses product-style branding, device options, and a formal signature to create a trustworthy appearance.
3	Urgency and pressure	The 48-hour expiration and "act quickly" language discourages careful verification.

Step 4 - Investigate the Download Options

The three platform options in the email are presented as download links. In a safe investigation workflow, the links should be inspected without clicking them. The provided scenario shows that each option opens the same login page.



Observed destination `my.site.net/pwnexecs/`

Why the page is suspicious

The landing page is not an ordinary software download page. It presents a branded login form requesting a Username and Password, plus a Continue with Google option. In the context of an unsolicited software-installation email, this is consistent with a credential-phishing workflow designed to capture authentication information.

Important safety practice

Do not enter credentials, click through the login flow, or install the offered software. Preserve the message and its artifacts for security analysis, and use the organization's established reporting/quarantine process.

Investigation Findings & Final Disposition

Indicator	Evidence
Sender/domain mismatch	imaginarybank@gmail.org does not match the organization's corporate domain.
Poor language quality	Multiple spelling and grammar mistakes reduce credibility.
Unexpected software request	ExecuTalk was not previously discussed, yet the recipient is urged to install it.
Urgency	A 48-hour expiration creates pressure to act without verification.
Suspicious destination	The links lead to my.site.net/pwnexecs/ rather than an expected official site.
Credential collection	The destination presents a username/password login form and Google sign-in option.

FINAL DISPOSITION

QUARANTINE

Rationale

The message contains several independent phishing indicators that reinforce one another. The safest response is to quarantine the email, prevent credential entry and software installation, and report the incident through the organization's security process.

Skills demonstrated

Phishing detection | Email header analysis | Social engineering analysis | Suspicious URL investigation | Credential-phishing identification | Incident triage | Security awareness

Disclaimer: This document describes a fictional, simulated training scenario for educational and portfolio purposes.